Britain and Tibet, but not by successive Chinese governments. And it was here at Bumla that one of the most decisive battles was fought during the 1962 War.

Fighting erupted early on the morning of 23 October 1962 as Chinese forces north of the pass unleashed a massive artillery barrage on the Indian side. Explosions lit up the sky and echoed between the mountains. At daybreak, the Chinese had overrun the nearest Indian position, a small outpost manned by 30 soldiers from the paramilitary Assam Rifles; 17 men lay dead, and the 13 survivors were captured alive. A somewhat stronger Sikh regiment, which was based a distance away from the actual pass, put up fierce resistance—until they ran out of ammunition and had to withdraw.[2]

With a total strength of six infantry regiments and an independent battalion, the victorious forces of China's PLA could begin their advance without much hindrance. The Indians had hundreds of troops in the area, but they were poorly equipped and supply lines from the plains of Assam in the south were long and hazardous. Only jeeps and convoys of pack animals could make it all the way to Tawang, the main town in the northwestern corner of what was then called the North-East Frontier Agency (NEFA), an administrative unit under the state government of Assam, and now is the Indian state of Arunachal Pradesh. There was no resistance at Tawang, as the Indian Army had evacuated the town during the night after the attack on Bumla. Tawang fell into the hands of the PLA on 24 October 1962.

The Chinese assault on Indian positions along the frontier had actually begun on 19 October, with the bombardments of Indian army positions northwest of Tawang followed by massive artillery barrages and infantry attacks on 20 October at Thagla ridge, west of Bumla and near the border with Bhutan. On the same day and at the very same time in the morning, other Chinese regiments attacked Indian outposts in Ladakh in the northwestern corner of Kashmir at the other end of the Indian subcontinent. Thus, the war was not confined to the NEFA, though the losses were the heaviest on the eastern front. At Thagla, the PLA wiped out almost the entire Indian Seventh Brigade and captured its commander, Brigadier John Dalvi. Unable to withstand the onslaught of the stronger and more heavily armed units of the PLA, India's defences in the western part of NEFA were in disarray.